

When Appliances Start To Think

PANKAJ RANA | CEO, Hisense India



Pankaj Rana is refreshingly resistant to the forecaster's vice. The Hisense India CEO walks us through how televisions, ACs, and washing machines acquired intent over the past 25 years — and then declines, with rare candour, to predict beyond the next decade. What he does predict is quite sharp, though.

How has tech evolved over the past 25 years with Digit?

Twenty-five years ago, a television was a bulky CRT that displayed channels and little else. Air conditioners were single-speed units that ran at full power regardless of the room's needs. Washing machines had fixed cycles and no sense of the load inside them. These were appliances: functional, static, unintelligent. What has changed since is the introduction of intent. Today's televisions process picture quality in real time using AI engines. Air conditioners read ambient conditions and adjust compressor speeds automatically. Washing machines sense fabric type and water hardness before selecting a cycle. Publications like Digit were instrumental in building consumer awareness of these shifts. Their hardware reviews and product testing gave Indian buyers the vocabulary to understand and demand better technology. That editorial rigour quietly raised expectations across the entire

consumer electronics and home appliance industry.

How is technology expected to transform our lives over the next 25 years?

Honestly, even as a technocrat, predicting 25 years is difficult. What I can say with confidence covers the next 5 to 10 years, and within that window, the changes will be dramatic. Televisions will understand viewing habits deeply, offering personalised recommendations and sending notifications to your smartphone: last Friday you watched this, are you interested in watching it again this Friday? It becomes a connected home solution, not a single device talking to one person. Air conditioners will move

beyond reading current outdoor temperatures to predicting the next week's weather and adjusting proactively. With pollution a genuine concern in India, air conditioning technology is also evolving to integrate air purification, removing the need for a separate device. Refrigerators and washing machines will follow the same connected logic. Beyond 10 years, frankly, nobody knows.

A message for Digit on completing 25 years

Twenty-five years in any industry is remarkable. In technology media, it is extraordinary, because we all know how many brands came and disappeared from the global market in that same period. If Digit has sustained and grown through those 25 years, it means one thing: the reviews were honest and the information shared with consumers was rigorous. For those of us on the industry side, tough editorial assessments have always pushed us to think harder about our products, about what needs to improve, about what consumers actually deserve. At Hisense India, we share that same instinct. Our focus is on product performance rather than advertising noise, and that is a value Digit has upheld for a quarter century. Congratulations to the entire Digit team. You survived a tough industry. That, in itself, says everything. 



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